

Psalms 109

The Prayer Against the Accuser

For my love they are my adversaries: but I give myself unto prayer
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Hold not thy peace, O God of my praise;*
- 2 *For the mouth of the wicked and the mouth of the deceitful are opened against me: they have spoken against me with a lying tongue.*
- 3 *They compassed me about also with words of hatred; and fought against me without a cause.*
- 4 *For my love they are my adversaries: but I give myself unto prayer.*
- 5 *And they have rewarded me evil for good, and hatred for my love.*
- 6 *Set thou a wicked man over him: and let Satan stand at his right hand.*
- 7 *When he shall be judged, let him be condemned: and let his prayer become sin.*
- 8 *Let his days be few; and let another take his office.*
- 9 *Let his children be fatherless, and his wife a widow.*
- 10 *Let his children be continually vagabonds, and beg: let them seek their bread also out of their desolate places.*
- 11 *Let the extortioner catch all that he hath; and let the strangers spoil his labour.*
- 12 *Let there be none to extend mercy unto him: neither let there be any to favour his fatherless children.*
- 13 *Let his posterity be cut off; and in the generation following let their name be blotted out.*
- 14 *Let the iniquity of his fathers be remembered with the LORD; and let not the sin of his mother be blotted out.*
- 15 *Let them be before the LORD continually, that he may cut off the memory of them from the earth.*
- 16 *Because that he remembered not to shew mercy, but persecuted the poor and needy man, that he might even slay the broken in heart.*
- 17 *As he loved cursing, so let it come unto him: as he delighted not in blessing, so let it be far from him.*
- 18 *As he clothed himself with cursing like as with his garment, so let it come into his bowels like water, and like oil into his bones.*
- 19 *Let it be unto him as the garment which covereth him, and for a girdle wherewith he is girded continually.*
- 20 *Let this be the reward of mine adversaries from the LORD, and of them that speak evil against my soul.*
- 21 *But do thou for me, O GOD the Lord, for thy name's sake: because thy mercy is good, deliver thou me.*
- 22 *For I am poor and needy, and my heart is wounded within me.*
- 23 *I am gone like the shadow when it declineth: I am tossed up and down as the locust.*
- 24 *My knees are weak through fasting; and my flesh faileth of fatness.*
- 25 *I became also a reproach unto them: when they looked upon me they shook their heads.*
- 26 *Help me, O LORD my God: O save me according to thy mercy:*
- 27 *That they may know that this is thy hand; that thou, LORD, hast done it.*
- 28 *Let them curse, but bless thou: when they arise, let them be ashamed; but let thy servant rejoice.*
- 29 *Let mine adversaries be clothed with shame, and let them cover themselves with their own confusion, as with a mantle.*
- 30 *I will greatly praise the LORD with my mouth; yea, I will praise him among the multitude.*
- 31 *For he shall stand at the right hand of the poor, to save him from those that condemn his soul.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 109 is the strongest of the Psalter's imprecatory prayers, calling down an extensive, unsettling list of curses on a specific enemy who has repaid love with hatred and false accusation. Rather than acting on personal vengeance, the psalmist hands the entire matter over to God in prayer, a pattern the New Testament echoes when Peter cites verse 8 regarding Judas. Henry treats the psalm not as a model for personal cursing but as an example of relinquishing the desire for vengeance entirely into God's hands rather than either suppressing it or acting on it directly.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-5

The prayer opens with a plea for God not to remain silent, since the mouths of the wicked and deceitful have opened against him, surrounding him with words of hatred and fighting him without cause. The wound is described as especially bitter because it comes in return for love: for his love they are his adversaries, but he gives himself to prayer rather than retaliation—repaying evil for good, hatred for love.

Verse 6-10

A series of specific curses follows, invoking a wicked accuser to stand against the enemy, his prayer itself to be counted as sin, his days to be few and his position taken by another. His children are pictured fatherless, his wife a widow, his children wandering as beggars, seeking bread far from their ruined homes—consequences extending, in the imagery, well beyond the offender himself.

Verse 11-15

The curses intensify: an extortioner seizing all he has, strangers plundering his labor, no one showing him mercy or favor to his fatherless children, his posterity cut off, his name blotted out within a generation. The iniquity of his fathers is asked to be remembered before the Lord rather than forgotten, his family's sin kept continually in view rather than allowed to fade.

Verse 16-20

The reasoning behind the curses is restated: he showed no mercy, persecuted the poor and needy, and sought to kill the brokenhearted, loving cursing so thoroughly that it should now come upon him, wrapped around him like clothing, seeping into him like water or oil into bone. This, the psalmist declares, is simply the reward due from the Lord to his adversaries for their own chosen speech against him.

Verse 21-25

The tone shifts to personal vulnerability: do this for me, O God, for Your name's sake, because Your mercy is good, deliver me, for I am poor and needy and my heart is wounded within me. Physical decline is described—fading like a shadow, tossed like a locust, knees weak from fasting, flesh failing—alongside public humiliation, becoming a reproach, an object others shake their heads at.

Verse 26-31

The prayer closes with a direct plea for help and a clear boundary drawn: let them curse, but You bless; let my adversaries be clothed with shame, but let Your servant rejoice. The psalmist commits to praising the Lord greatly and extolling Him among the multitude, resting on the closing confidence that God stands at the right hand of the poor, ready to save from those who would condemn their soul.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Confronted with betrayal that repays love with hatred and false accusation, the psalmist neither suppresses the desire for justice nor acts on it personally, but hands the entire matter—including its most severe consequences—over to God in prayer. The psalm's disturbing specificity is itself instructive: real anger at real injustice can be voiced honestly to God without requiring the one praying to enact vengeance themselves.

Application for life today.

When you have been genuinely wronged, especially by someone you loved or trusted, resist both suppressing the resulting anger and acting on it yourself; follow this psalm's pattern of voicing it specifically and entirely to God instead. Notice the psalm's own turn toward personal vulnerability (vv. 22–25)—injustice done to you is allowed to be named as suffering, not only processed as principle. Let the closing confidence—that God stands at the right hand of the poor and needy (v. 31)—anchor you when you feel unable to defend or vindicate yourself.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where have you been repaid evil for good, as this psalm describes (v. 5), and how does its example of handing the matter entirely to God rather than retaliating challenge your own response?

2. How does the psalmist's honest naming of his own suffering and vulnerability (vv. 22–25), alongside his anger at the offender, give you permission to hold both in your own prayer?

3. What would it mean to actually rest in verse 31's confidence—that God stands at the right hand of the poor and needy—the next time you feel unable to defend yourself?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).